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This Is Anastasia

BY GLEB BOTKIN

*A one-time playmate of the late Tsar's youngest daughter
explains his belief that she still lives*

I THINK no mystery in the annals of royalty is more romantic than that of Grand Duchess Anastasia, also known as Madame Tchaikowsky, who, having had her day of fame, now dwells secluded near New York, the guest of a certain Miss Annie Burr Jennings. Miss Jennings is a wholesome type of American woman, a D. A. R., and in general a person as alien to the Russian Court as China is to French cooking. In spite of that, or because of it, the young Russian Grand Duchess and the elderly Daughter of the American Revolution live together in perfect harmony.

To me there is no mystery attached to the case of Madame Tchaikowsky. I not merely believe her to be Anastasia — I know that she is. The guest of Miss Jennings is the youngest daughter of the late Emperor Nicholas II, and the only survivor of the Ekaterinburg massacre.

On what my knowledge rests I shall endeavor to explain in this article. I can speak with freedom now, because I have officially and actually withdrawn from the case. I have not seen the Grand Duchess for about a year, and do not propose to see her. I feel no particular interest in the eventual out-

come of her case. In fact, I suspect that it may never have any outcome, save the gradual passing of all its participants from natural causes. At the end, I think the identity of Anastasia will still remain officially a mystery. Thus, for the first time (and I hope for the last) I can here relate what I know of Anastasia, not as one of her champions, but as an outsider who simply happens to be sure of certain facts.

I HAVE known Anastasia since she was seven and I was eight. She has never been very pretty, except for her eyes, exact copies of the soft blue eyes of her father. But what she lacked in beauty, she made up in charm. Even as a child she could be tremendously attractive. She was always gay, witty, possessed of a great sense of humor and, when she wanted, delightfully kind. True, she could also be very haughty, but she never was toward me. The courtiers adored her, yet also considered her an *enfant terrible*. Among her cousins, who knew her better and worshipped her less, she had the reputation of being a little nuisance.

To me, however, Anastasia seemed wholly charming. We used to play to-

gether, to exchange messages through my father, to plan together funny pictures which I later executed for Anastasia and for her sisters and brother. I knew that she was wilful, but she was always cheerful, entertaining and kind.

SOME nine years after I first saw Anastasia, we all found ourselves in exile in Siberia. Tobolsk, where we were sent, was truly a God-forsaken place, 250 miles away from the nearest railroad, buried from October to May in snow, with the temperature at about 40° Fahrenheit below zero.

Our party of exiles was placed in two houses, across the street from each other. I found myself in one house with my father, my sister, and several members of the Imperial Suite. The Empress was very anxious to have my sister and myself study and play together with her children. She repeatedly asked the revolutionary Commissars who guarded us to grant the necessary permission. For some mysterious reason the Commissars stubbornly refused. All we could do then was to exchange with the Grand Duchesses greetings through windows, and messages carried by my father, who, as personal physician to Tsar Nicholas, was allowed to visit the prisoner.

Most of our time my sister and I spent perched on window sills. Through father we knew from day to day every little event in the Imperial Family, while they learned from him everything that we were doing. With the eldest Grand Duchess, Olga, I exchanged verses, for she was a poet of real talent and followed my work in the same field with interest, often giving me helpful advice. For Anastasia and the little heir to the

throne, I was still making my funny drawings.

It was, to say the least, a dreary winter, but it would have been drearier still, if it hadn't been for Anastasia. Not yet seventeen, she managed to keep her courage and amuse others even at the darkest moments. My father often said: "How touching the Grand Duchesses are! Today again I heard them whisper to one another: 'Papa is gloomy. We must cheer him up.'" And it was generally Anastasia who led the way.

THE Emperor had certainly sufficient reason to be gloomy. He had abdicated in the mistaken hope that his abdication would unite all political factions and enable Russia to win the war. Instead, he saw his former Empire crumble under his eyes, betray his Allies, and finally succumb to the shameful peace of Brest-Litovsk. Our personal situation was also precarious enough. The soldiers who guarded us had been appointed by the Kerensky Government. The Bolsheviks could not dispatch enough troops across the deep Siberian snow to remove those guards. Thus, we were entirely in the power of a gang of irresponsible soldiers who soon lost every vestige of discipline, spent their time in drunken orgies, and renewed daily their threats to shoot us all.

Once we were officially informed that we were going to be shot "in the course of the next twenty-four hours." These hours, which I spent pacing my room and trying to visualize the forthcoming shooting, I shall not forget. What helped me most to preserve my calm was the ticking of the clock. It sounded so peaceful, so

unalterable, a true symbol of eternity. It occurred to me how little the death of all of us would mean, when it wouldn't even interrupt that quiet, eternal "tick-tack-tick-tack." And I kept pacing the room and listening to the clock. I have never known why the threat was not carried out.

MY SISTER and I were promised not to be separated from the Imperial Family. Nevertheless we were forcibly separated by the Bolsheviks in the spring of 1918. The Imperial Family and my father were taken to Ekaterinburg, my sister and I were left in Tobolsk. Soon afterwards Tobolsk was captured by the "Whites." We were saved. But what happened to the Imperial Family and to father? We knew nothing. At the first opportunity I rushed to Ekaterinburg, arriving there with a detachment of White troops, about a week after the tragic death of the Imperial Family. But I could learn nothing. It was only in the spring of 1919 that a lengthy and rather sloppily conducted investigation, led by Judge Sokolov, arrived at the conclusion that the whole Imperial Family and my father were shot on the night of July 17, 1918, and their bodies burned twenty-four hours later, in a nearby forest. There were persistent rumors that one or two of the Grand Duchesses had escaped, but these have never been seriously investigated. Besides, Ekaterinburg was soon recaptured by the Reds, and the investigation was abandoned.

In 1920 I escaped to Japan. In 1922 I arrived in the United States. Wherever I went I heard of rescued Grand Duchesses. I even met some of them. It came to the point when

every announcement of another "discovery" of a rescued Grand Duchess caused me to fly into fits of anger. It was only a cruel and impudent evocation of memories too painful to dwell on, or talk about.

Then, in 1925, I read a cable from Germany about the discovery in Berlin of a Madame Tchaikowsky who claimed to be Grand Duchess Anastasia. The same afternoon a reporter called on me. I declared emphatically that Madame Tchaikowsky was either a fraud or a lunatic. Shortly after the publication of that interview I received an anonymous letter reproaching me for giving out such reckless statements. What, my anonymous correspondent wanted to know, if Madame Tchaikowsky was indeed Anastasia? I laughed and threw the letter into the waste basket.

SEVERAL months passed, and I began to hear about Madame Tchaikowsky again. But every bit of new information about her, that reached me, was always more baffling and disturbing. At length I began to investigate the matter earnestly. The more I investigated, the more I had to admit that this pretender had at least a good case. But then, she herself seemed to remain completely indifferent to her own fate. Whatever case she had was made by her adherents, whose number steadily increased. This alone was unprecedented. Nevertheless I remained highly skeptical.

At last, late in 1926, I received a hysterical letter from my sister. She had visited Madame Tchaikowsky and found her to be indeed Anastasia. But Anastasia was sick, penni-

less, persecuted for incomprehensible reasons by her own relatives. Something had to be done to save her. I had every confidence in my sister's judgment and truthfulness, and yet this time I couldn't quite believe even her. But I naturally was greatly upset, and as soon as I could manage it, went to Europe. Early in May, 1927, I arrived at the ancient Bavarian castle of the Duke of Leuchtenberg, who at the time was offering refuge to Madame Tchaikowsky. At first she refused to see me. I waited from day to day. Then, one afternoon, while I was in the hall, the door opened and before me appeared — Anastasia.

IT IS difficult to describe the shock I experienced, but from the first moment that I saw Madame Tchaikowsky, I knew her to be Anastasia. There could be not the slightest doubt about it. She, likewise, recognized me at once and on the same afternoon she singled out from the many drawings I brought to show her those which I had made in Siberia.

Her situation was pathetic. Her own relatives tried to have her arrested, kidnapped. There had been several attempts on her life. German newspapers, allied with Anastasia's uncle, were waging a ruthless campaign against her, trying to prove that she was a Polish peasant, and clamoring for her arrest. The Duke of Leuchtenberg was losing his head. It was all mysterious and dreadful. I felt myself plunged into the Middle Ages. I could find no explanation of what was going on, but there was no time to search for explanations. One had, at all cost, to get Anastasia out

of Europe. I promised to do it; but how?

In June, 1927, I was back in New York, but nobody wanted to listen to me. Some of my friends thought that I was losing my mind, others that I had embarked on some unscrupulous political adventure. But gradually people began to be more attentive and I received several offers to bring Anastasia to this country. Among them was one from Mrs. William B. Leeds, the former Princess Xenia, a distant cousin of the Emperor. This offer was accepted; but even then, it was February, 1928, before Anastasia finally reached the United States.

I thought that now her troubles were over, but I was very much mistaken. The mystery began gradually to clear up. The Emperor had left a fortune to his daughters in England. There was also money and real estate in Germany and Finland. Anastasia's relatives had long been searching for that fortune, but couldn't locate it. It was Anastasia herself who finally gave the necessary information. Then her relatives proclaimed her an impostor and began to claim her fortune for themselves.

TO ADD to other complications, it was just in the summer of 1928 that the money had to be given to Anastasia's aunts, unless a claim for Anastasia's rights were made officially before then. Anastasia received my promise that I would try to save her fortune for her. Meanwhile, however, she quarreled with me and with everybody else, until she was completely isolated on the Leeds estate.

Nevertheless, Anastasia's fortune was duly rescued and tied up in the banks. And then Anastasia's hosts

delivered an ultimatum. She was either going to renounce her claims and let her aunts inherit her money, or else she was to leave their house in forty-eight hours. Did they doubt her identity? Oh, no; they readily admitted it. But somehow the policy of the Imperial Family had prevailed. Anastasia was not to be officially acknowledged.

As a consequence of these decisions, I found myself one day with Anastasia and an American friend, driving in a car along the Long Island highways. What were we going to do? Neither of us had any money, and worse than that, we could not feel certain of Anastasia's safety. Even some of us who had befriended her had been mysteriously threatened.

WE DECIDED for safety first. There was a tiny studio apartment in the attic of an old house on Fifty-sixth Street, New York, east of Lexington Avenue. It was more than modest, full of dust, suffocatingly hot, but it was safe, for it was occupied by a certain John R. Colter, a journalist who had always championed Anastasia's cause, without having ever seen her. I knew that no more loyal person ever lived than he. He would defy the whole universe, but Anastasia would be safe with him. Thither we went, and for the first time I breathed with relief. Anastasia was safe. Luckily she was satisfied with a vegetarian diet. Colter and I had just enough money between us to buy her some lettuce and a tomato for supper.

Then other friends came to the rescue. Anastasia went to live in Garden City, Long Island. Often

some of my friends who lived only a few blocks away from her, would gather at my house in the evening, and ask: "Have you heard about Anastasia lately? Is it true that she went back to Europe? Where do you think she can be hiding?"

Anastasia remained undetected and unperturbed in Garden City until Christmas, 1928, whereupon she accepted an invitation from Miss Jennings.

MY FIRST instant recognition of Anastasia in Leuchtenberg's castle might conceivably have been a mistake, but any doubt on my own part as to her identity became impossible after I had seen her daily from August till January. I must say that Anastasia has been totally misrepresented by her own adherents who, in trying to provoke more sympathy for her, and explain away her often bewildering actions or statements, created an entirely wrong picture of her and defeated their own purpose. Anastasia can indeed be bewildering and even exasperating, but only to those who did not know her in the old days. Her personality hasn't changed in the least. She can still be witty and humorous, kind and adorable, but she can also be an *enfant terrible*, and what seemed just naughtiness in childhood can be very trying in a grown up person. She suffers from all the idiosyncrasies common to royalty, and has besides inherited the difficult disposition of her mother, the late Empress Alexandra. She insists on most rigid observance of court etiquette. Yet she hates everything associated — like the Russian language — with her fearful family tragedy. It is on these grounds that

she considers it insulting to be asked questions and that she dislikes to talk Russian. Accordingly, she would often give deliberately nonsensical and untruthful answers or would refuse to speak her native tongue. Her adherents who tried to represent her as a paragon of all virtues and a most truthful person started the very harmful myth that she lost her memory and forgot the Russian language. All of which is pure fiction. Anastasia's memory is amazingly good. Many a time she has reminded me of little incidents and unimportant events which I had long since forgotten myself, but remembered the moment she mentioned them. Actually, Russian is the only language she knows in perfection; but she stubbornly insists on talking either in English or in German, although she speaks both of those languages with a pronounced accent.

BUT if one doesn't violate a fundamental of court etiquette by asking Anastasia questions, she herself will talk freely of her past. And I must say that it is a veritable ordeal to listen to her descriptions of the tragedy of Ekaterinburg. She tells in detail of all the events preceding the shooting on the night of July 17, 1918. Her last recollection is that she saw the Commissar Yourovsky shoot the Emperor through the head. She herself hid behind her sister Olga. Then she heard Olga scream and lost consciousness. She came to herself in a peasant cart, travelling along the highway with two men and two women. She was covered with wounds and for a long time remained semi-conscious. Later it was explained that the two men were

among the Bolshevik shooting squad and accompanied the bodies of the victims to the forest. They noticed that Anastasia was alive and in the night preceding the cremation of the bodies, stole her and brought her to their farm. From there, taking along their mother and sister, they started on the same night in a cart in a southwestern direction. After many weeks of weary travel they reached Rumania.

There Anastasia married one of her rescuers and gave birth to a son. Soon afterward her husband, Tchaikowsky, was killed in the streets of Bucharest. Anastasia's son was taken away from her and placed in an orphan asylum where he is said to have died. Anastasia made her way to Germany, where she wanted to find her godmother, Princess Irene of Prussia. Arrived in Berlin, she threw herself from a bridge in a fit of despair, but was rescued by the police. Since she refused to answer a single question, she was placed in an insane asylum. It was there that she was recognized by Russian visitors who had known her in her childhood. They obtained her release from the asylum in 1922.

EVER since then, the controversy about Anastasia's identity has raged with increasing fury. Many a time Anastasia, in consequence of her many wounds, was on the verge of death. As late as 1925 the doctors pronounced her beyond hope. She survived, but it was only after her arrival in this country that she recovered almost completely.

I must say that Anastasia's account of her rescue contradicts in nothing the findings of the Sokolov

commission, but supplements and explains them on many points. There exists much circumstantial evidence confirming all that she says. Were Anastasia to go to court I believe that she would certainly win her case. But a litigation of this kind would require considerable capital and it must be realized that Anastasia herself is penniless.

WHAT makes the situation even more difficult is Anastasia's own attitude toward the whole case. She is highly indignant at her relatives' behavior toward her. But her indignation is, so to speak, a political one. She considers herself the head of the House of Romanov and regards her aunts' refusal to recognize her mostly in the light of a rebellion. I never heard her express any indignation on moral or humane grounds. But to public opinion she is supremely indifferent and accordingly does nothing to win any supporters. To all my representations on the subject, she invariably answered:

"What do I care what some sort of people think or say about me? No matter what they say or think, I am still the Grand Duchess Anastasia."

She has more or less the same attitude toward the courts. What she really wants is not so much a legal recognition by the courts, as a voluntary submission of her revolutionary relatives.

But perhaps Anastasia's main trouble is her suspiciousness. It is not surprising that a person who has endured her dreadful experiences would become suspicious. But I

think that with Anastasia this trait is more inherited than acquired. Her mother, Empress Alexandra, was suspicious to the point of abnormality. For instance, in the winter of 1917-18, during our Siberian exile, the Empress suddenly began to suspect my father of being a revolutionary. Anastasia likewise sees enemies everywhere. It is enough to arouse her displeasure on even some trivial matter, to have her suspect one of evil designs. Kind and charming as she can be toward those she trusts, she becomes haughty the moment she loses confidence. In this manner she has antagonized in turn most of her champions.

FOR my part, though I am no longer active in the task of establishing her identity, I would like to see the case solved, if only for the sake of history. Incidentally, there is a peculiar coincidence that might interest the mystically inclined. The Romanovs became first nationally prominent in Russia when Tsar Ivan the Terrible married a young woman of an obscure middle class family, Anastasia Romanovna. She enjoyed great popularity, and in 1613 her grand-nephew Michael Romanov was elected to the Russian throne. Thus it was an Anastasia who brought the Romanovs out of obscurity, and it is with an Anastasia that they are now dropping back into obscurity. For whatever may be the outcome of the case of Anastasia, there can be no doubt that the Romanovs have played their final part in history.